Mobile Application Development

Is it worth learning mobile dev in 2026?

Yes

- Everyone's on their phone, and apps get the camera, GPS, Bluetooth, Face ID
- One codebase, both platforms (Flutter, React Native, KMP)
- AI edge integration is a hot new thing (on-device AI experiences).
- Mobile devs are more niche, so less competition (but also fewer job opportunities).

No

- Web apps get a lot done, no need for mobile
- AI and no-code tools can build simple apps for you
- App stores are a pain: reviews, fees, rules
- Setup is a hassle (Xcode, Android Studio, emulators…)

Takeaway

> Still worth it, as long as you build what the web can't: fast apps that use the phone's hardware and on-device AI.

Popularity

- Language popularity in 2026
- Notice the percentage values of these languages: `Dart` / `Kotlin` / `Swift` / `Java` compared to `JavaScript`.
- I would say that around 10%-20% of developers (that filled the responses) are mobile devs.

Overview of Mobile Development

Mobile Development

- **Native**
  - Andriod: `Java` or `Kotlin`
  - iOS: `Objective-C` or `Swift`
- **Cross-platform**
  - React Native: `JavaScript`
  - Flutter: `Dart`
  - Kotlin Multiplatform: `Kotlin`

Native vs Cross-Platform

	Native	Cross-Platform
Time to market	Slow	Fast
Features	Full	Limited
Performance	More	Less
Cost	More	Less

Popularity

- Flutter vs React Native in 2024

> I cannot find a good source for 2026.

React Native vs Flutter

	React Native	Flutter
Language	JavaScript	Dart
UI	Native UI and iOS components	Custom widget
Dev API	Core + 3rd party libs	Core
Dev option	More versatile	More streamlined
Performance	Slower	Faster

Source

Preflight Project